

Semicolons

SEMICOLONS CONNECT SECTIONS OF TEXT THAT ARE CLOSELY RELATED.

Semicolons can be used to indicate a close relationship between main clauses or to separate complex items in a list. They also precede certain adverbs when they are used as conjunctions.



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- **Never use** a semicolon to **connect a main clause to a subordinate clause**. A comma and a conjunction should be used. For example, “Sam had two red T-shirts, **which** were new.”
- **Use** a semicolon to **connect two main clauses** that are not joined by a conjunction.

Connecting

A semicolon is used to join two main clauses and show that they are of equal importance and closely related. These clauses can stand alone as separate sentences, or they can be connected by a comma and a conjunction.

May was warm; it was pleasant.

This clause is closely related to the previous main clause because it provides information as to why May was pleasant.

May was warm; it was pleasant.
cities were rainy: London; Paris,



Identifying when to use a semicolon

Many people have trouble deciding when to use a colon or a semicolon. Both are used to connect two main clauses that are closely related, but the colon indicates specifically that the second sentence is a direct explanation or a result of the first.

The second clause does not explain why it was freezing, nor is it a direct result of it being freezing, so a semicolon is used to connect the two sentences.

The weather was dreadful.

It rained every day.

The weather was dreadful: It rained every day.



The second clause explains why the weather was dreadful, so a colon is used to connect the two sentences.

It was freezing.

He was grateful for his coat.

It was freezing; he was grateful for his coat.

